

Detecting Usernames Through Abuse of Functionality Vulnerabilities - Websecurity (English translation)

Виявлення логінів через Abuse of Functionality уразливості - Websecurity - Author not stated, websecurity.com.ua.

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Content (translated into English)

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Detecting Usernames Through Abuse of Functionality Vulnerabilities

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Over the past few years, I have encountered many times a feature on some websites (primarily email services and large projects) that makes it possible to check whether a given username is available. This allows a user to create a unique username when registering on the website. And so, in March 2008, when I developed my Brute force login identifier program (for discovering usernames, something I have to deal with during security audits), I decided to conduct a detailed study of the username-checking feature.

This feature allows an attacker to discover valid usernames in the system (login enumeration). In other words, the presence of this feature on a website gives rise to an Abuse of Functionality

vulnerability. I have provided examples of similar vulnerabilities, in particular, on hulu.com and on www.youtube.com.

Let us examine the algorithm for discovering a username on YouTube.

If you enter the username being checked in the Username field of the registration form (<http://www.youtube.com/signup>) and click Check Availability, the system will perform a check and provide a response (this feature is implemented using AJAX). If the response is "Username unavailable," that username exists in the system; if the response is "Username available!", that username does not exist in the system.

Thus, you need to check a list of usernames using the Check Availability feature and select those for which the response is "Username unavailable." You can then create a list of valid usernames.

If this feature has no protection against automated attacks (that is, if there is an Insufficient Anti-automation vulnerability), as is the case most of the time, it allows automated discovery of usernames in the system. This can be done using username brute-forcers, for example, my Brute force login identifier program. The usernames discovered can subsequently be used to determine the passwords of the website's users.

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